



Intro to Management - Professor Vogelmann



RU TRADING

Final Team Project

PRESENTED BY:

Saleha Iftikhar, Jaden Booth, Ruozhu Shen, Aileen Castro





Our Business Concept

Business Concept: provide an online second-hand goods trading platform for campus students.

- The platform primarily targets university students:
 - Helps them buy and sell used items such as textbooks, electronics, and furniture.
 - Students can post item information via a mobile app or website, including pictures, prices, and contact information, so other students can browse and purchase directly.
- Students are price-sensitive → can help them save money while also reducing waste and promoting resource reuse.
- Platform also provides on-campus offline meeting points to ensure convenient and secure transactions.
 - If students are still concerned about safety, the website can also hire delivery drivers to complete the delivery of goods.





Customer Value Proposition

Our campus secondhand platform provides students with a **safe, affordable, and convenient channel** to exchange items directly within the campus community.

- **Unlike general secondhand trading platforms**, our platform is only open to students who use campus email authentication.
 - → ensures the credibility and security of transactions.
- Students can quickly find low-priced textbooks, electronic products, or dormitory supplies without paying additional shipping fees or worrying about trading with strangers outside the campus.
 - At the same time, the platform encourages the reuse and recycling of items to reduce waste → in line with the growing environmental awareness of college students.
- The platform also provides **on-campus safe handover points and a user credit rating system** to make the transaction process more reliable and efficient.
 - Compared with traditional external secondhand platforms, our service brings greater convenience, credibility, and community value to students.



Our Statements

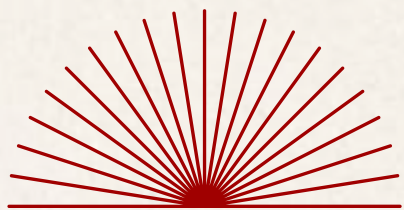


Vision Statement: To foster environmental consciousness by promoting sustainable consumption.

Mission Statement: Our mission is to provide a convenient platform that encourages college students to buy and sell second-hand goods. Transforming sustainable choices into smart, everyday alternatives that reduce waste and save money.

Statement of Core Values:

- **Sustainability:** Our focus is to reduce waste and provide environmentally friendly alternatives.
- **Trust and reliability:** We prioritize providing a secure and safe platform.
- **Student empowerment:** Our focus to simplify students' lives by decreasing their financial burdens.



Financial and Strategic Objectives

Financial Objectives:

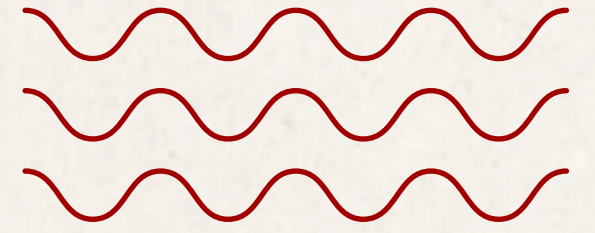
1. Achieve an annual net income of \$10,000 by the end of the calendar year 2027.
2. Pay off all borrowed debt by the end of year 5 of operation.
3. By the end of the first year, the platform's commission income will cover at least 60% of operating costs, gradually reducing its reliance on external funding.

Strategic Objectives:

1. Launch the business at five different colleges within the first two years.
2. Gain at least 10 new customers each month during the first year of operation.
3. Reach at least 2,000 student customers through social marketing, with at least 5% of those customers purchasing or selling an item through our company website during our first year of operation.



Corporate Social Responsibility Key Initiatives + Rationale



Partnering with Environmental Student Clubs

- This CSR initiative would allow us to work with each college on reducing waste on campus and promoting the recycling of items that other students can use.
 - The student clubs can host big fairs each semester, using our business to recycle used items.

Safe Delivery Initiative

- This initiative would guarantee that our business is promoting safe transactions with secure meeting points and optional delivery options if students do not want to meet in person.
 - We can work with the campus security at each college to ensure that the designated meeting points are safe to use.

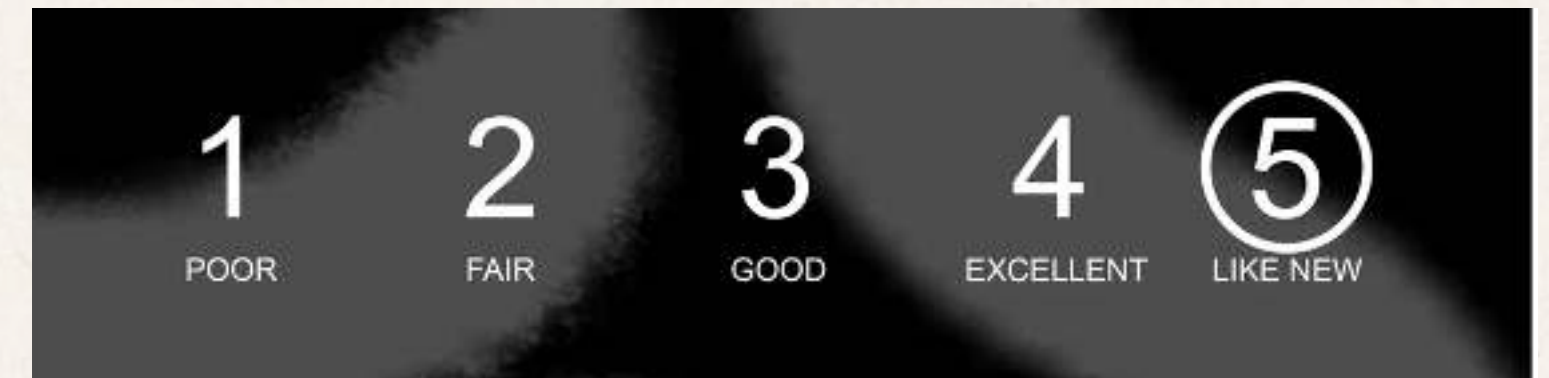
Student Employment Program

- This initiative would create jobs for students on each campus as we could hire them for roles such as content creators and campus ambassadors, who are promoting our business while creating jobs for them

Description of New Product/Service selected by the Team

Paid Item Authentication & Grading System:

The platform would offer a paid authentication process for high-demand electronics. A representative would physically inspect the item and assign it a grade (e.g., "Like New," "Good," "Fair").



National Expansion Decision, Approach, and Rationale

Decision: We should stay in our own state and expand to other colleges in-state first in order to increase revenue and keep the entire business nearby for now.

Approach: Franchise. College markets differ (size, culture, demand). Local student leaders or entrepreneurs understand their campus best and can adapt RU Trading accordingly. Franchising reduces capital strain, encourages innovation at the local level, and keeps expansion sustainable while maintaining overall brand presence.



Selected country for global expansion, opportunities in this country, challenges, and overall rationale for selection

Germany

Opportunities in this Country:

- Large student base with disposable income.
- Strong sustainability culture (eco-conscious students will embrace secondhand goods).
- Reliable legal and regulatory system.

Challenges:

- Strict regulations, particularly GDPR, place high demands on platform compliance.
- Operating costs are high, including labor, rental, and compliance costs.
- There are already established secondhand trading platforms in the market, creating significant competitive pressure.

Overall Rationale:

Germany provides the best balance of stable politics, a strong economy, cultural alignment, and student demand for sustainable living. It is less risky than India or Brazil, making it an ideal first global market.



Expansion Strategy and Entry Strategy and Rationale

Expansion Strategy: Partial Customization. While standardization can reduce costs and accelerate expansion, German students have high expectations for environmental protection, data protection, and user experience. A complete standardization approach might fail to gain market acceptance. We recommend maintaining consistency in the platform's core functionality and branding while also implementing some customization, such as adding features that comply with EU privacy protection requirements and highlighting environmental awareness campaigns and services. This approach balances efficiency with local adaptability and is more conducive to long-term development.

Entry Strategy: Joint Venture.

1. Local Resource Support: Germany has strict laws and regulations, particularly data protection requirements like GDPR. Joint ventures with local partners can leverage their experience in legal compliance and approval processes, reducing entry barriers.
2. Market Understanding: Local partners are familiar with German university campuses and consumer habits, helping to better identify target student groups.
3. Risk Sharing: Compared to self-development, joint ventures can share financial and operational risks, reducing initial investment pressures.
4. Brand Promotion: Partners can assist with localized promotions to enhance brand awareness and market acceptance.



Key job selected, summary of responsibilities, qualifications required, compensation plan, and advertising plan, criteria for selection

Key Job Selected: Delivery Staff

Summary of Responsibilities:

1. Responsible for the safe and efficient pickup and delivery of used items on campus.
2. Communicate with buyers and sellers to coordinate pickup and delivery times and locations.
3. Ensure items are delivered on time and in good condition, and promptly report any delivery progress or issues.

Qualifications Required:

1. Familiar with campus routes and able to quickly plan optimal delivery routes.
2. Excellent communication skills and customer service awareness.
3. Responsible and punctual, able to handle multiple orders during peak hours.
4. Healthy and able to carry small to medium-sized items.
5. Experience in campus courier or food delivery preferred.

Compensation Plan:

1. Base pay: \$17 per hour.
2. A performance bonus is available for completing 20 or more orders per week.
3. Transportation allowance (such as electric scooter or bicycle maintenance) is provided.
4. Flexible work hours, with shifts available based on business volume.

Advertising Plan:

1. Post job postings both on and off campus: including on the Rutgers website, local community websites, and part-time job search platforms.
2. Post job postings to the surrounding community, local residents, or Uber Eats/DoorDash part-time drivers to attract experienced part-time workers.
3. Post QR code posters on campus and in surrounding commercial areas (coffee shops, convenience stores, and takeout areas).

Criteria for Selection:

1. Familiarity with campus maps or navigation skills is required.
2. Excellent communication and time management skills are required.
3. Strong sense of responsibility and the ability to ensure safe and timely delivery of items.
4. A driver's license or the ability to use an electric scooter or bicycle is preferred

Process for Selection:

1. Initial Screening: Qualified candidates will be screened based on their resume.
2. Interview: In-person or online interviews will be conducted, with a focus on assessing responsibility and communication skills.
3. Probationary Period: A 2-3 day trial delivery period will be arranged to assess route familiarity and work performance.
4. Final Hire: Permanent hires will be confirmed based on probationary performance and customer feedback.

Employee motivation initiatives

1. Monthly “Top Trader” Recognition

- A monthly “Top Trader” award is established to recognize outstanding performance or teamwork.
- Winners receive a small bonus (e.g., \$50).
- Public praise is given in team communications to increase visibility and recognition.

2. Bi-Weekly 1-on-1 Check-ins

- Schedule a 30-minute one-on-one meeting between employees and managers every two weeks.
- Discuss workload, challenges, successes, and career development.
- Help employees feel supported, listened to, and cared for.

3. Formalized Flexible Work Policy

- Implementing a formal flexible work policy, especially convenient for student employees.
- Allowing employees to adjust their schedules according to coursework, exams, or remote work needs.
- Increasing employees' control over their work style and pace.

4. Increased Employee Autonomy & Ownership

- Assign specific projects or key performance indicators to employees, giving them a sense of ownership.
- For example: Customer service staff are responsible for developing new FAQ resources.
- This enhances skills, fosters a sense of responsibility, and increases their participation in the company's success.



Announcement for informing employees of the departure of two key employees

Dear Team,

I want to inform you that a couple of our peers have recently decided to move on from their positions. While we're sad to see them go, we respect their decisions and wish them all the best.

As a management team, we've reflected on how we can better support you and create a more engaging work environment. Starting this month, we're rolling out several new initiatives designed to improve motivation, flexibility, and growth opportunities:

- A peer recognition program to celebrate your contributions
- More flexible scheduling options to fit your academic needs
- Monthly performance bonuses for outstanding work
- Clear paths for advancement within the team
- Regular team-building events to strengthen our community

We're committed to making this a community where you feel valued, supported, and excited to contribute. If you have any potential ideas or feedback, we'd love to hear from you. Thank you for all that you do.

Sincerely,

RU Trading



Key drivers and actions selected to achieve high levels of employee engagement

- **Design purposeful roles:** Ensure every employee understands their role and feels they are making a tangible contribution to the organization.
- **Encourage employee feedback:** Continuously collect employee opinions through surveys, meetings, etc., to improve work experience and increase engagement.
- **Organize team community activities:** Strengthen connections among employees through team building and social activities, creating a more cohesive work environment.
- **Establish employee recognition and praise mechanisms:** Promptly acknowledge employee efforts and achievements to enhance a sense of belonging and work enthusiasm.
- **Develop managers into coaching leaders:** Help managers better support employee development and improve their communication and mentoring skills.
- **Provide clear career development paths:** Through training, mentorship programs, and promotion opportunities, help employees see their future growth direction and enhance long-term commitment.



SIPOC for key process

Suppliers: Student sellers

Inputs: Product details (photos, descriptions, prices), login credentials

Process:

1. Seller creates an account
2. Uploads listing info
3. Platform verifies and posts the listing
4. Buyer browses and selects the item
5. Buyer contacts seller through secure chat
6. Payment and handoff arranged
7. Seller confirms transaction completion

Outputs: Successful exchanges, feedback, transaction data, and user satisfaction

Customers:

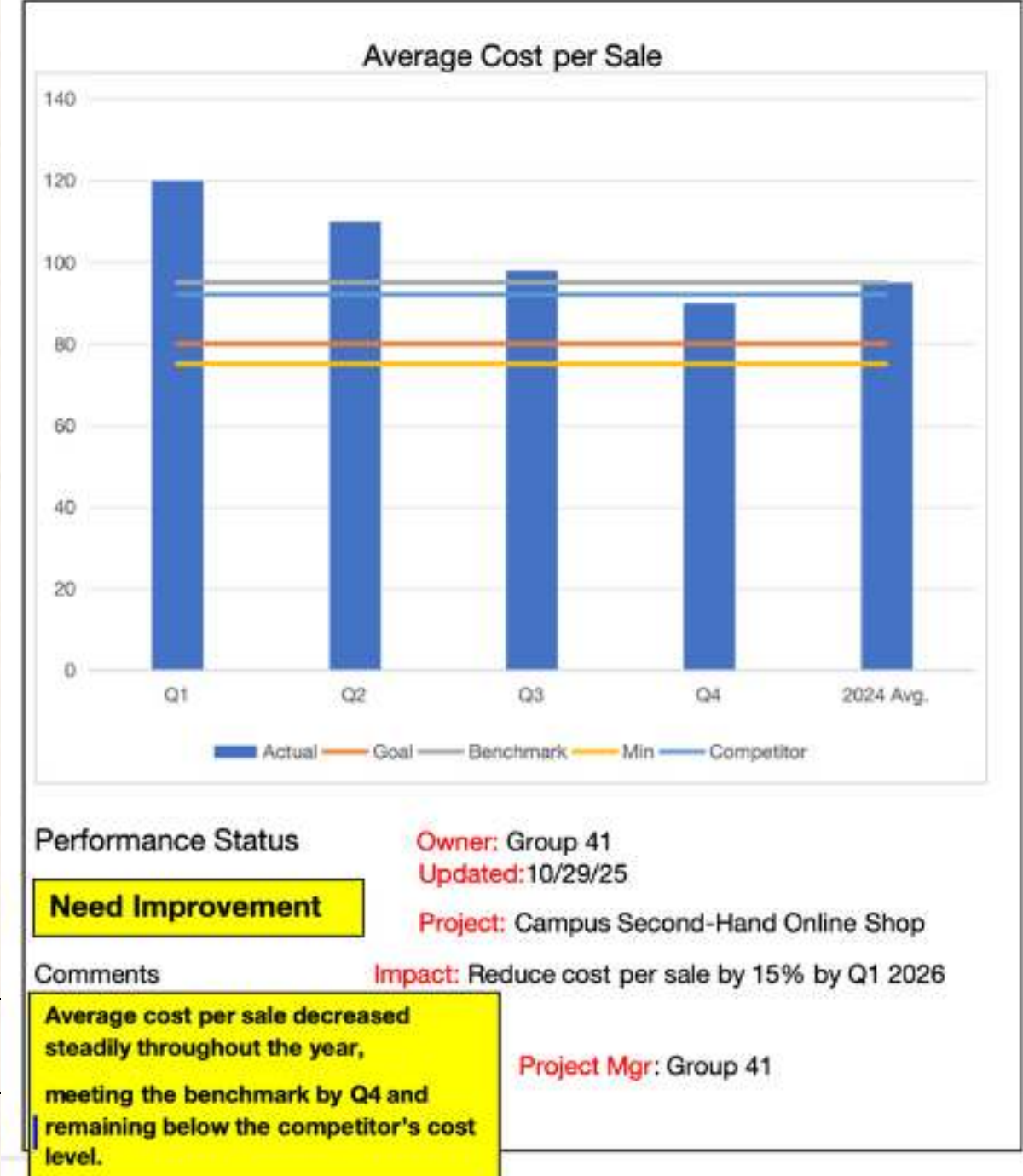
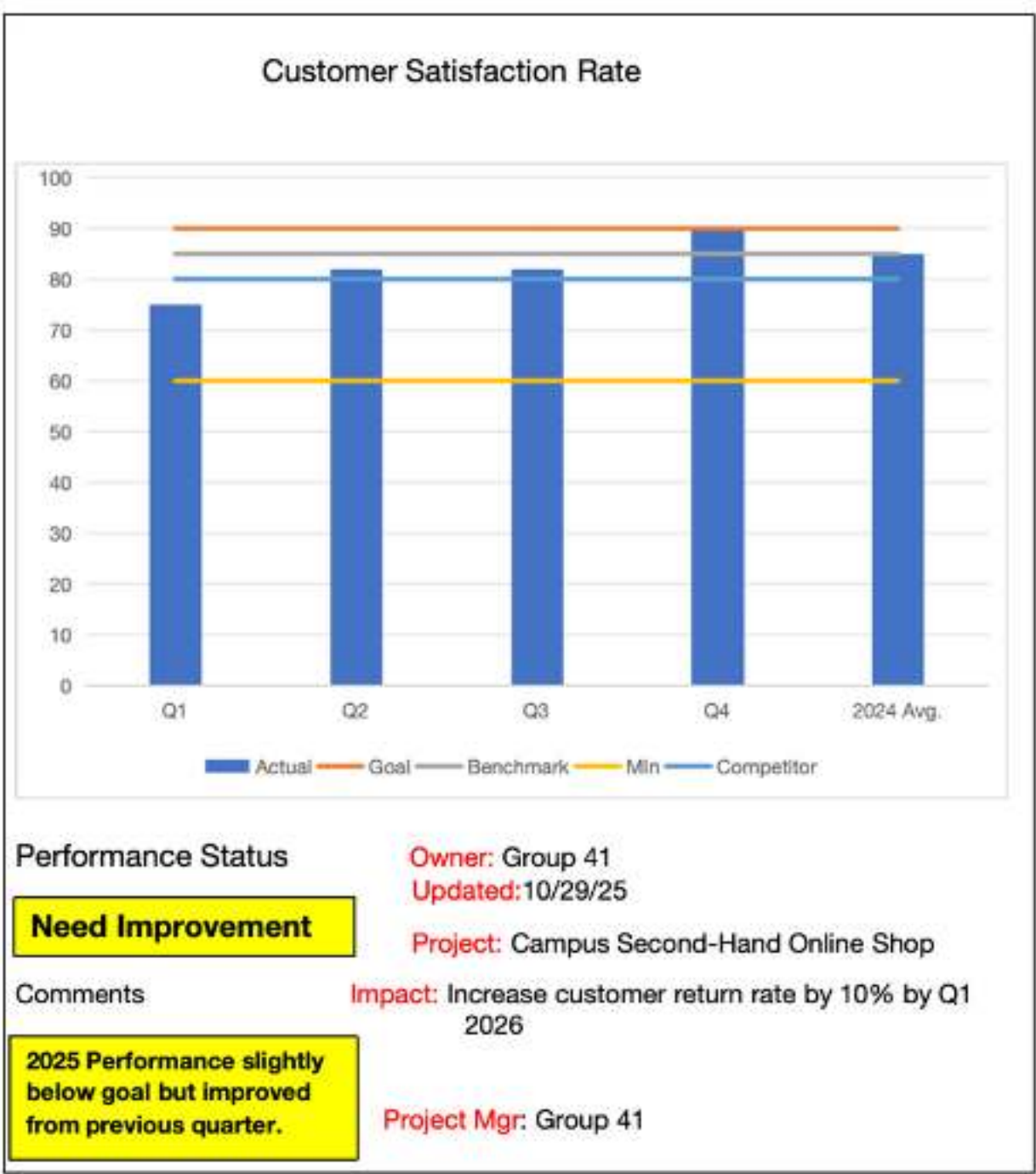
Target Customers: Rutgers students buying/selling secondhand items.

Desired Behaviors: Frequent use of the platform, positive reviews, and word-of-mouth promotion.

Customer Requirements: Secure transactions, accurate listings, user-friendly interface, fast communication, and trusted verification.



Effectiveness measurement chart and efficiency measurement chart



Description of key initiative to improve the process described in item #15



RU Trading will introduce an AI-based item recommendation system and priority listing feature to improve product visibility. The platform will also send automated buyer-seller follow-up reminders to speed up communication. These process changes aim to reduce inactive listings and improve the match rate between buyers and sellers, achieving a faster average sale time. Target Completion Date: March 31, 2026

Team decision on whether to sell the business or not and rationale

Not to sell the business.

Although the sale would provide massive financial gains for shareholders, selling to inexperienced owners from a politically unstable region risks the company's long-term sustainability, the livelihoods of thousands of employees, and the company's global reputation.

The platform's core objective is to serve the student body and promote resource recycling and sustainable development on campus. If acquired by foreign capital, the new owner might shift the platform's operational direction, focusing more on commercial profits and neglecting student needs and trust.

A sale could lead to the company headquarters relocating from the US, resulting in job losses for many student employees involved in developing and maintaining the platform, and potentially even the leakage of student privacy data, damaging the university's reputation



Summary of why our business has been successful

Our business success stems from a clear campus focus, stable process management, and continuous operational optimization. With security, environmental friendliness, and convenience at its core, the platform ensures a reliable and smooth experience at every step, from listing and review to delivery, through a clear SIPOC process. We also incorporate AI recommendations and automatic reminders to improve transaction efficiency.

We value employee engagement, implementing flexible scheduling, performance-based rewards, bi-weekly communication, team activities, and career development planning to keep employees more involved and thus improve service quality. Furthermore, our global expansion strategy, starting in Germany, mitigates risk through partial localization and joint ventures. The team has made a firm decision not to sell the company to maintain our long-term mission and user trust.

Overall, our success stems from accurate market demand matching, efficient processes, technological upgrades, employee engagement, and a sound expansion plan, enabling the platform to remain competitive on campuses.

